

Random Lives, Curated History

Who do we imagine when we imagine the past? Predict a life, draw from real demographic odds, and notice which stories history selects.



SCAN TO DRAW A LIFE

STATISTICAL LIFE

The person is not real. The site turns population data and historical scholarship into a simulated life, then adds narrative reconstruction.

1 Predict - before opening the site (2 min)

Before opening the site, picture one person selected at random from **everyone who has ever lived**.

Born about: year _____ Region: _____ Likely work: _____

Lifespan: years _____ Children: _____ Survived to 5? Yes / No Literate? Yes / No Confidence
1 2 3 4 5

2 Draw two random lives (8-10 min)

For each life, accept the first draw. After **When** and **Where**, pause and predict the odds. Then continue through **Life** and **Story**.

LIFE 1

FIRST DRAW - NO REDRAW

WHEN + WHERE

Year: _____

Place: _____

Sex: _____

PAUSE BEFORE REVEALING THE ODDS

Predicted life expectancy: years _____

Predicted under-5 risk: % _____

Predicted children per woman: _____

REVEAL THE ODDS + DRAW THE LIFE

Life expectancy / under-5 risk: _____

Marriage / children: _____

Lifespan or current age: _____

Work + material conditions: _____

Literacy + travel: _____

One loss, shock, or constraint: _____

Most surprising detail: _____

LIFE 2

FIRST DRAW - NO REDRAW

WHEN + WHERE

Year: _____

Place: _____

Sex: _____

PAUSE BEFORE REVEALING THE ODDS

Predicted life expectancy: years _____

Predicted under-5 risk: % _____

Predicted children per woman: _____

REVEAL THE ODDS + DRAW THE LIFE

Life expectancy / under-5 risk: _____

Marriage / children: _____

Lifespan or current age: _____

Work + material conditions: _____

Literacy + travel: _____

One loss, shock, or constraint: _____

Most surprising detail: _____

Do not redraw. A dull, recent, or unfamiliar life is part of the result. Selection begins when we decide which lives are worth keeping.

From a life story to factful history

A vivid biography can correct our imagination - or become another misleading anecdote. Separate what the lives reveal from what they cannot establish.

3 Become the editor (optional, 3 min)

Choose a year or place that you think will produce an interesting life. Your choice is now part of the evidence: notice what attracts your attention.

LIFE 3: EDITOR'S CHOICE		OPTIONAL - THIS DRAW IS NOT RANDOM
Chosen year / place: _____	Why this seemed interesting: _____	
Lifespan + childhood odds: _____	Family + work: _____	
Material life + mobility: _____	Detail you would put in a story: _____	
What did choosing this life add - and what might it distort? _____		

4 Audit the story (2 min)

The site combines several kinds of evidence. In Lives 1-3: **underline** one population or demographic estimate; **circle** one individualized outcome drawn from those odds; and add a ? beside one narrative detail that may be reconstructed or model-supplied.

Strongest for broad claims: birth distribution, population, mortality, fertility, and other documented rates. More tentative: some details of work, dwelling, diet, travel, and connective biography. Check **Full Sources** when a detail matters.

5 Keep three truths in view (2 min)

THINGS WERE AWFUL One severe harm or constraint: _____ _____	THINGS HAVE IMPROVED One dimension with documented better odds: _____ _____	THINGS COULD BE BETTER One remaining deprivation or gap: _____ _____
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6 Test the selection (2 min)

Which life would be most likely to appear in a textbook or news story - and why? _____

What disappears from history because it is ordinary, gradual, private, or undocumented? _____

How did choosing Life 3 change the picture created by the random lives? _____

7 Write a factful biography (1 min)

"_____ was born in _____ around _____. This life makes _____ visible. Our prediction missed _____. The story suggests _____, but it cannot establish _____."

EXIT QUESTION What can three biographies make visible that a chart hides? What can a chart establish that three biographies cannot?

Source: Any Human Ever (anyhumanever.com) and its Full Sources pages. Generated people are not real. Use the lives to humanize distributions and test assumptions, not as evidence that a particular person existed.